there to exact revenge. Dost Mohammad thanked him for the offer, but asked him instead to provide 700 horsemen to accompany him across the Oxus. The governor agreed, prepared the necessary supplies and equipment and assigned 700 troopers as escort.[88]

From this point, the Amir's fortunes began to improve. He crossed the Oxus and made his way safely to Balkh. On the way, as he passed through the villages of northern Afghanistan, he realised that the mood had changed while he had been in prison and that disillusion with the Anglo-Sadozai regime was now widespread. 'Along the road he questioned travellers,' wrote Maulana Kashmiri in the *Akbarnama*, seeking news from Kabul and Bukhara.

One day he saw amongst the wayfarers
A young man who had set out from Kabul

He asked him: 'What is the state of affairs in the land of Kabul?
What do they say of the Shah and the Firangi chiefs?

What plans have they for war and peace?
And what of the Khans? Are they as before . . . ?'

The young man said: 'O mighty ruler of good fortune!
Shuja is not that Shuja of yore, his mind is not the same as before

Like Kings he has a seat upon the throne
But he does not rule the land nor have his hand upon the treasury

Secretly, he is in anguish, his soul exhausted
Less than a watchman, such a king is he.'[89]

The Amir eventually made his way to his former host, the Mir Wali at Khamard, where he found his son Afzal Khan waiting for him. Here the Uzbek leader again offered to help him – the Mir Wali had owed his power and position entirely to Dost Mohammad's patronage – but also brought him bad news. The Amir's brother, Nawab Jabar Khan, had despaired of the Amir ever freeing himself from his prison and had just surrendered himself to the British authorities, along with the Amir's harem. Undaunted, the Amir decided he had no option but to fight, and again publicly declared a jihad on the Firangis. For the Afghan poets this was a heroic moment:

He girded his loins to battle the enemy
And sought out his scattered army